

Wine & Food Pairings

The Classic Matches — and the Science Behind Why They Work

A good pairing does not require rules — it requires understanding. When you know why tannins cling to fat, why high acid cuts through richness, and why sweetness calms heat, every pairing decision becomes intuitive. This guide covers the classic matches for every major wine style, the principles behind them, and the exceptions worth knowing. kazmicellars.com

THE THREE PAIRING PRINCIPLES

Match the Weight	The single most reliable rule in wine and food pairing. A delicate wine disappears next to a rich, heavy dish — and a bold, tannic red overwhelms a light, delicate one. Match light to light (Muscadet with oysters, Beaujolais with charcuterie) and full to full (Barolo with braised beef, oaked Chardonnay with lobster). Weight is about both the body of the wine and the richness of the dish.
Mirror or Contrast	Two equally valid approaches — you can complement or cut. Mirroring means pairing similar flavours together: buttery Chardonnay with a cream sauce, fruity Grenache with a fruit-based sauce. Contrasting means using the wine's character to cut through the food's richness: crisp Riesling with fatty pork belly, tangy Sauvignon Blanc with rich goat cheese. Both work — choose deliberately rather than accidentally.
Tannin Needs Fat & Protein	This is the chemistry behind red wine with red meat. Tannins are polyphenol compounds that bind to proteins on the palate, creating a drying, gripping sensation in the mouth. When you eat fatty, protein-rich food (lamb, beef, aged cheese), the tannins bind to the food proteins instead of yours — the wine suddenly feels smoother and the food tastes richer. A very tannic wine without food feels harsh; the same wine with a well-marbled steak is transformed.
Acid Cuts Richness	High-acid wines act like a squeeze of lemon on the palate — they refresh, brighten, and lift. This is why Champagne works with oysters, Riesling with pork belly, and Sangiovese with tomato-based pasta. The acidity in the wine performs the same function as the lemon wedge on a piece of fish. The meal feels lighter, less cloying, and the wine tastes more vivid. When in doubt, match high-acid wines to rich, fatty, or oily foods.
Sweet Calms Heat	The most practical rule for spiced and aromatic cuisines. A slightly off-dry or sweet wine (Riesling Spätlese, Gewurztraminer, Vouvray demi-sec) dramatically reduces the perception of chilli heat in food. The residual sugar binds to the capsaicin compounds in a way that dry wines cannot. Conversely, a very dry, high-alcohol red with a spiced dish will amplify the heat — the alcohol intensifies the burn. This is why off-dry Riesling is the world's greatest spice-food wine.
Regional Pairings Work	The simplest shortcut: what grows together usually goes together. Italian Sangiovese was made for Italian food. Albariño for Galician seafood. Rioja Tempranillo for Spanish lamb. Alsace Gewurztraminer for Alsatian cuisine (choucroute, Munster cheese, spiced dishes). Centuries of co-evolution between local food and local wine have produced pairings that work almost every time. When travelling, simply drink what the locals drink with what the locals eat.

RED WINE PAIRINGS

Wine / Grape	Style Note	Best Pairings	Why It Works
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Cabernet Sauvignon	<i>Full body · very high tannin · structured</i>	Rack of lamb · beef ribeye · duck confit · aged hard cheese	<i>High tannin needs fat and protein — the classic chemistry. Lamb is the textbook match.</i>
Merlot	<i>Full body · medium tannin · plush</i>	Beef · duck · pasta Bolognese · mushroom risotto · veal	<i>Softer tannin is more food-versatile. The plum and chocolate notes complement richness.</i>
Pinot Noir	<i>Light body · low tannin · high acid · earthy</i>	Salmon · duck breast · chicken · mushrooms · charcuterie · veal	<i>Low tannin means it works with fish. Earthy notes mirror mushroom and forest flavours.</i>
Syrah / Shiraz	<i>Full body · high tannin · peppery</i>	Grilled lamb · game · BBQ · smoked meats · hard aged cheese	<i>The rotundone (pepper) compound in the wine mirrors herbs in roasted and spiced meats.</i>
Grenache	<i>Medium body · low tannin · warm · spiced</i>	Lamb tagine · tapas · charcuterie · pizza · Mediterranean dishes	<i>Warm spice in the wine mirrors the spice in Mediterranean and North African dishes.</i>
Tempranillo	<i>Medium body · medium tannin · aged oak</i>	Lamb · suckling pig · aged Manchego · cured Ibérico · veal	<i>American oak vanilla complements the sweetness of roast meats and the nuttiness of cheese.</i>
Sangiovese	<i>Medium body · very high acid · sour cherry</i>	Bistecca Fiorentina · pasta al ragù · pizza · salumi · hard Italian cheese	<i>Very high acid is made for tomato — why Italian food and Italian wine are inseparable.</i>
Nebbiolo (Barolo)	<i>Full body · very high tannin & acid</i>	White truffle · braised beef · aged Parmesan · wild mushrooms · game	<i>Tannins need the richest, most protein-dense foods. Truffle is Barolo's greatest match.</i>
Malbec	<i>Full body · medium tannin · dark fruit</i>	Beef asado · lamb chops · empanadas · grilled meats · BBQ	<i>Argentina's national pairing — what grows together goes together. Malbec with beef is definitive.</i>
Cabernet Franc	<i>Medium body · floral · herbal · medium tannin</i>	Duck · pork · mushrooms · goat cheese · salmon · charcuterie	<i>More aromatic and lighter than Cab Sauv — goat cheese is one of its great unexpected matches.</i>
Zinfandel	<i>Full body · bold · jammy · high alcohol</i>	BBQ ribs · pizza · burgers · spiced dishes · aged hard cheese	<i>Bold fruit and spice mirrors bold flavours — Zinfandel thrives with American BBQ culture.</i>
Mourvèdre / Monastrell	<i>Full body · very high tannin · gamey</i>	Game · cassoulet · lamb · smoked sausage · earthy dishes	<i>The wine's inherently gamey, meaty character needs equally robust, savoury food to match it.</i>
Gamay (Beaujolais)	<i>Light body · very low tannin · fresh</i>	Charcuterie · chicken · light fish · goat cheese · picnic foods	<i>Low tannin and high freshness make this the most food-versatile red. Serve slightly chilled.</i>

Amarone	<i>Very full body · intense · raisined · high alcohol</i>	Game stew · aged hard cheese · dark chocolate · richest braised dishes	<i>Needs equally strong flavours to match its extraordinary intensity. Never pair with light food.</i>
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WHITE WINE PAIRINGS			
Wine / Grape	Style Note	Best Pairings	Why It Works
Chardonnay (oaked)	<i>Full body · buttery · rich</i>	Lobster · scallops · veal · cream sauce pasta · roast chicken	<i>Fat mirrors fat — the butter and cream in the wine complements the dish's richness.</i>
Chardonnay (unoaked)	<i>Light-medium · mineral · citrus</i>	Oysters · white fish · shellfish · sushi · grilled sea bass	<i>Minerality mirrors the sea. Chablis with oysters is one of wine's great natural pairings.</i>
Sauvignon Blanc	<i>Light body · very high acid · herbal</i>	Goat cheese · oysters · asparagus · salads · grilled vegetables · sushi	<i>High acid cuts the chalk-fat of goat cheese. Herb notes bridge to green vegetables.</i>
Riesling (off-dry)	<i>Light · very high acid · slight sweetness</i>	Pork belly · Thai food · Indian curry · spiced dishes · duck	<i>Sweetness calms heat; acidity cuts fat. The world's greatest wine for spiced cuisine.</i>
Riesling (dry)	<i>Light · very high acid · bone dry</i>	Trout · pork · sauerkraut · charcuterie · mild Asian dishes	<i>Laser acidity cuts through fatty and rich dishes without the distraction of sweetness.</i>
Champagne & Sparkling	<i>High acid · fine bubbles · toasty</i>	Oysters · caviar · sushi · tempura · fried chicken · anything fried	<i>Acidity and CO2 refresh the palate. Champagne works with almost anything, especially fried food.</i>
Gewurztraminer	<i>Full body · low acid · lychee · floral</i>	Foie gras · Munster cheese · Peking duck · Moroccan tagine · Thai	<i>Aromatic intensity matches fragrant and spiced dishes. Alsace's great pairing wine.</i>
Viognier	<i>Full body · low acid · apricot · floral</i>	Lobster · scallops · aromatic herb dishes · mild Indian · soft cheese	<i>Richness pairs with richness. Floral note complements cream, herbs, and shellfish.</i>
Chenin Blanc (dry)	<i>Medium body · very high acid · versatile</i>	Roast chicken · pork · smoked fish · Brie · goat cheese	<i>High acid and versatile flavour make Chenin the most food-flexible white wine.</i>
Albariño	<i>Medium body · high acid · saline</i>	Shellfish · octopus · ceviche · white fish · paella · tapas	<i>Salinity mirrors the sea. Albariño with Galician shellfish is the definitive regional pairing.</i>
Grüner Veltliner	<i>Medium body · high acid · peppery</i>	Wiener Schnitzel · asparagus · sushi · vegetables · mushrooms	<i>White pepper bridges to herb-crusted dishes. Works with asparagus — a notoriously wine-hostile veg.</i>

Sauternes / Sweet White	<i>Very sweet · honeyed · botrytis</i>	Foie gras · Roquefort blue · crème brûlée · fruit tarts · aged cheese	<i>The Sauternes-foie gras pairing is one of the world's great culinary discoveries — sweet meets rich.</i>
Pinot Gris (Alsace)	<i>Full body · slightly off-dry · spiced</i>	Pork · spiced dishes · smoked salmon · Munster cheese · charcuterie	<i>Body and slight sweetness handle fatty, smoked, and spiced foods with ease.</i>
Assyrtiko	<i>Medium body · very high acid · volcanic mineral</i>	Grilled octopus · oysters · shellfish · white fish · Greek mezze	<i>Volcanic salinity mirrors the sea. Made for coastal Mediterranean seafood.</i>

THE CLASSIC MATCHES — TIME-TESTED AND DEFINITIVE

The Pairing	Wine	Why It's Definitive
Oysters & Chablis	<i>Unoaked Chardonnay</i>	Kimmeridgian limestone packed with fossilized oyster shells produces a wine with a saline, almost briny mineral quality. The same flavour as the oyster itself. No better pairing exists.
Lamb & Cabernet Sauvignon	<i>Bordeaux / Napa Cab</i>	Tannins bind to the fat of the lamb, making the wine smoother and the meat richer. The herbal notes in the wine mirror the herb crust. A pairing that has defined fine dining for centuries.
Sauternes & Foie Gras	<i>Sauternes (Bordeaux)</i>	The botrytis-derived sweetness amplifies the unctuous richness of foie gras rather than cloying it — the wine's acidity keeps everything in balance. One of gastronomy's great discoveries.
Champagne & Oysters	<i>Blanc de Blancs / NV</i>	The combination of high acidity, fine bubbles, and mineral character creates an almost cleansing effect on the palate with every briny, creamy oyster.
Sancerre & Goat Cheese	<i>Loire Sauvignon Blanc</i>	The Crottin de Chavignol goat cheese and Sancerre Sauvignon Blanc are both from the same part of the Loire Valley — a geographic pairing refined over centuries.
Barolo & White Truffle	<i>Nebbiolo (Piedmont)</i>	Both come from Piedmont; both have the same haunting earthiness, truffle, and tar character. One of the world's most expensive and most justified pairings.
Port & Blue Cheese	<i>Vintage or Tawny Port</i>	The sweetness of Port cuts the salt and sharpness of Stilton or Roquefort while the dark fruit complements the rich creaminess. A British tradition with very good reasons behind it.
Riesling & Pork	<i>German Spätlese</i>	The off-dry sweetness mirrors the slight sweetness of pork; the rapier-like acidity cuts the fat. Germany's great regional pairing — Riesling with roast pork, sauerkraut, and apple sauce.
Muscadet & Oysters	<i>Melon de Bourgogne, Loire</i>	The leanest, most saline white wine in France with the leanest, most saline food. Sur lie aging adds a cream note that bridges perfectly. Classic Atlantic coast pairing.
Barbera & Pizza	<i>Barbera d'Asti (Piedmont)</i>	Very high natural acidity mirrors tomato. Low tannin means no metallic clash with the pizza's varied toppings. Italy's most intuitive everyday pairing.

Gewurztraminer & Munster	<i>Alsace Gewurztraminer</i>	The Munster cheese and Gewurztraminer are both from Alsace. The intensely pungent, washed-rind cheese needs the aromatic power of Gewurztraminer to hold its own.
Amarone & Dark Chocolate	<i>Amarone della Valpolicella</i>	The dried-grape intensity and bittersweet character of Amarone is one of the few wines with enough power to meet dark chocolate as an equal rather than be overwhelmed by it.

WINE & CHEESE — A DEDICATED GUIDE

Cheese is one of wine's most natural partners — but the conventional wisdom ('red wine with cheese') is often wrong. In practice, white wines pair with cheese more reliably than reds, because the acidity in white wine cuts through the fat in cheese while the tannins in red wine can clash with it.

Cheese Type	Best Wine Match	Notes
Fresh Goat (Chèvre)	<i>Sancerre · Sauvignon Blanc</i>	The classic regional match — both from the Loire. Sauvignon Blanc's herbal, citrus acidity cuts the chalk-fat of fresh goat cheese perfectly.
Brie & Camembert	<i>Champagne · Burgundy Pinot</i>	The CO2 and acidity of Champagne cuts through the bloomy rind richness. A light, earthy Pinot Noir also works well.
Aged Parmesan	<i>Barolo · Barbaresco</i>	The crystalline, protein-rich texture of aged Parmesan is one of the few foods that can handle Nebbiolo's formidable tannins and make the wine taste smooth.
Aged Cheddar	<i>Cabernet Sauvignon · aged Port</i>	The fat in aged cheddar binds to Cab's tannins. Tawny Port with old cheddar is a classic English combination with centuries of history.
Manchego	<i>Rioja Reserva · Tempranillo</i>	The regional match — both from Spain. The nutty, buttery quality of Manchego complements the vanilla oak and dried cherry of Rioja Reserva.
Roquefort / Stilton (Blue)	<i>Sauternes · Vintage Port</i>	The sweetness of both wines cuts the salt of blue cheese. Sauternes with Roquefort is a classic French pairing; Stilton with Port is a classic British one.
Époisses (Washed Rind)	<i>Burgundy Pinot · white Burgundy</i>	The pungent, meaty rind needs an earthy, complex partner. White Burgundy (Meursault) matches the richness; red Burgundy mirrors the earthiness.
Comté / Gruyère	<i>White Burgundy · Chardonnay</i>	The nutty, long-aged character of Comté mirrors the hazelnut notes in oaked Chardonnay. One of the most harmonious and overlooked pairings.
Mozzarella & Burrata	<i>Soave · Vermentino · Albariño</i>	Light, delicate, fresh cheese needs a light, fresh wine. Heavy reds overwhelm it. Keep it Italian (or at least coastal) and the pairing will work.
Gorgonzola Dolce	<i>Moscato d'Asti · late-harvest</i>	The gentle sweetness and low alcohol of Moscato d'Asti is a beautiful match for the mild, creamy richness of Gorgonzola Dolce — neither overwhelms the other.

The White Wine with Cheese Rule

White wine generally pairs better with cheese than red wine — yet almost every restaurant and cheese board defaults to red. The reason: tannins in red wine clash with the fat and protein in most cheeses, creating a metallic bitterness. White wine's acidity cuts through the fat instead, making both the wine and cheese taste better. The exceptions are aged, very firm cheeses (Parmesan, aged Cheddar) whose protein structure can handle big red tannins.

Red Wine with Fish — When It Works

The rule 'red wine with fish' is wrong as a blanket statement but right as a starting point. The problem is tannin reacting with the iron in fish oils to create a metallic taste. Low-tannin reds avoid this entirely: Pinot Noir with salmon, Gamay with tuna, Barbera with oily sardines — all work beautifully. The fish to avoid with red wine is any very oily, strongly flavoured fish (mackerel, herring) where the clash is most pronounced.

The One Rule to Remember

If you remember nothing else: match the weight of the wine to the weight of the dish. A light wine with a delicate dish. A powerful wine with a rich, substantial dish. Everything else — the tannin chemistry, the acid and fat interaction, the regional matchmaking — is refinement on top of this single foundational principle.